THE GAZETTEER OF GRUNVYR · VOLUME III

OF THE FACTIONS OF THE DEEP SEAT

# THE SUNDERED HEARTH

*The Quarrels of Grunvyr, Their Leaders, and the Hand That Moves Among Them*



A RECKONING OF LOYALTIES · D.R. 1622

# A Reckoning of Loyalties

This third volume concerns the inside of Grunvyr — not its stone but its quarrels. Volume I named the seven great factions; this book gives them faces, leaders, and secret members, and sets out the great divide that splits the kingdom over a single question: how should Grunvyr go on? It contradicts nothing of the first two volumes. Rather it shows how the politics of the Hold and the horror of the deep are, in the end, the same crisis wearing courtly clothes.

For the divide is not merely reform against tradition. Beneath the open quarrel run hidden ones — a banking cabal, a hardline conspiracy, a foreign purse, a secret order of loremasters — and beneath them all reaches the true inner enemy: the cold hand of the deep, which does not belong to any faction because it works through every one.

### HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

Read Volumes I and II first. Every clan, leader, and threat here was established there; this volume deepens them and adds the covert powers no public gazetteer would dare record. Leaders are given system-neutral so you may stat them to taste.

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CHAPTER I

# The Divided Kingdom

Underking Vargin III is dying, and he has named no heir. That single fact has cracked Grunvyr open along every seam it owns. For a dwarf, the death of a childless king is not a sad occasion but a contest, for the Stonecrown passes by the confirmation of the Clan-Moot, and the Moot's seven votes are split as they have not been split in living memory. Every faction in the kingdom has spent this year jockeying for the throne — and, behind that, for the answer to a question older than the present king: what is Grunvyr to become?

## The Bones of the Quarrel

Three pressures grind together, each established in the earlier volumes, now brought to a head by the empty throne.

**The dwindling aurithal.** The kingdom's wealth, its enchantment-metal, and — though few say it aloud — its only ward against the gloaming, all run short with the Ninth sealed. Every plan for Grunvyr's future is, at root, a plan for how to spend or save what aurithal remains.

**The debt to Vendholm.** Grunvyr owes the human crown a great and growing sum, brokered through House Goldhand. To reformers the debt is a problem trade will solve; to traditionalists it is a leash in Margrave Vossheim's hand.

**The failing Door.** The Sealing Door has begun, this year, to hum. The Deepward know it; the Reckoners know it; and a few who should not know it have begun to whisper that the dead behind it are calling.

### HOW POWER IS HELD (A RECAP)

Three bodies share rule: the **Stonecrown** (the monarch, now failing); the **Clan-Moot** (seven clan-votes, which confirm the next monarch and alone may vote to open a sealed Delve); and the **Council of Hammers** (the executive — Forge-Master, Vault-Keeper, Deep-Warden, Gate-Warden, and High Reckoner). In a strong reign they balance. In a dying one, they are weapons, and everyone has reached for one.

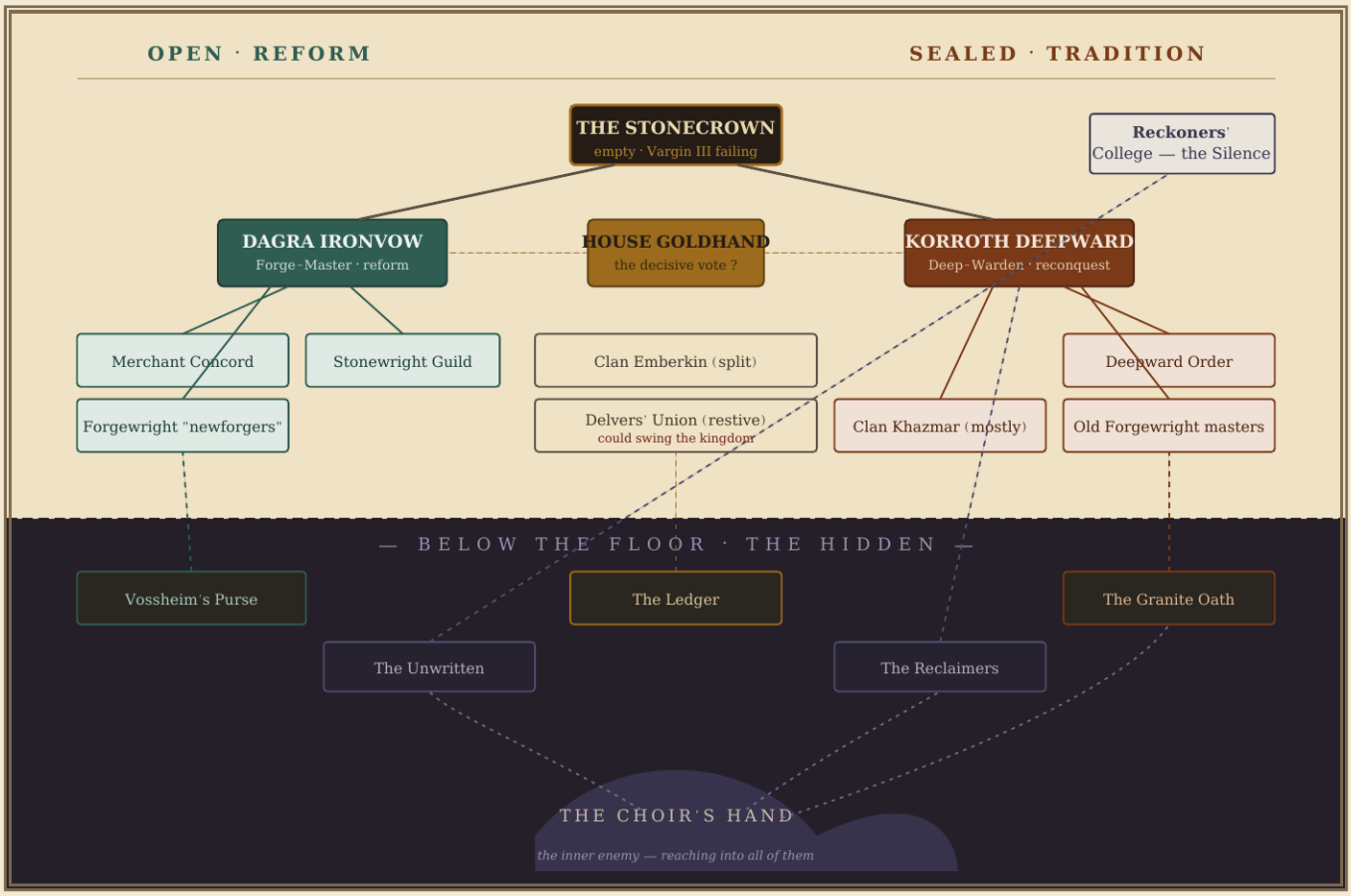
## Not Two Sides, but Five

Outsiders see Grunvyr's quarrel as reform against tradition, and that is where it begins. But there are at least five answers abroad in the Hold to the question of how to go on, and the next chapters trace each. Worse, the lines between them are not clean: a dwarf may be a public reformer and a secret traitor, a sworn traditionalist and an unwitting tool of the very deep he is sworn to fight. The hearth is sundered not in two pieces but in a dozen, and something cold has slipped into every crack.

> *"Ask a dwarf of Grunvyr who he stands with, and he will name a clan. Ask who he stands against, and he will lower his voice. Ask what he is afraid of, and he will not answer at all — because he has begun to suspect the answer is sitting at his own hearth."*
>
> — OPENING OF THIS VOLUME, IN MAEVIS STONELEDGER'S HAND

CHAPTER II

# The Map of Power




THE MAP OF POWER, D.R. 1622 — SOLID LINES, OPEN BACKING; DASHED LINES, COVERT. WHAT LIES BELOW THE FLOOR IS NOT IN THE PUBLIC BOOK.

The chart reads as a spectrum from reform (left) to tradition (right), with the empty Stonecrown above and **House Goldhand** at the pivot, its decisive vote unpledged. Above the floor sit the factions a Reckoner may name aloud. Below it lie the powers that work in secret — a banking cabal, a hardline conspiracy, a foreign purse, a hidden order of loremasters, and the heretic Reclaimers — and beneath them all, the cold shape of the **Choir's Hand**, whose dashed tendrils rise into faction after faction. Read this volume as a guide to that chart, from the top down.

CHAPTER III

# The Visions of Progress

The divide that splits Grunvyr is, at heart, a disagreement about survival. Every faction loves the kingdom; each is certain the others will destroy it. Five answers contend for the question of how Grunvyr should go on, and the tragedy of this year is that every one of them is, in some fatal way, correct about the others and wrong about itself.

## The Open Road

Held by the reformers — the Merchant Concord, the younger Forgewrights, much of Clan Stonewright, and championed by **Dagra Ironvow**. Sell aurithal abroad, refinance the Vendholm debt on fair terms, enlarge the Sunlit Gate, and trade Grunvyr back to greatness. *Its flaw:* aurithal is the ward against the deep. To sell it freely is to grow rich by disarming the kingdom — and to lean ever harder on a creditor who would like to own them.

## The Closed Door

Held by the isolationists — old Forgewright masters under **Durgan Emberkin**, much of Clan Khazmar, and the more rigid Deepward. Seal the Gate, repudiate the debt, hoard every gram of aurithal, and return to the deep-rooted ways that kept the kingdom whole for three thousand years. *Its flaw:* a sealed Grunvyr starves. It cannot grow its own bread, and a kingdom that will not trade for grain soon cannot pay its Wardens to hold any door at all.

## The Reconquest

Held by **Korroth Deepward** and his faction within the Order. End the long dread by force: open the Ninth, drive out the Gloamkin, reclaim the lost aurithal and the Stonefather's tomb, and make the kingdom whole again. *Its flaw:* it would do the one thing the Sealer forbade. Whatever Korroth believes he is reconquering, what he would actually accomplish is the opening of the Door.

## The Homecoming

Held by the Reclaimers under **Vesska Hollowtongue**. Open the Ninth not for conquest but for love — to bring home the abandoned dead and the founder's bones, as oath demands. *Its flaw:* the voices they would answer are not their ancestors but the Pale Choir wearing them. The Homecoming is the Throne's own plan, dressed as devotion (see Chapter IX).

## The Silence

Held by the Reckoners' College under **Maevis Stoneledger**. Change nothing that could wake the deep. Keep the Door, keep the debt manageable, keep the truth buried, and outlast the crisis as the kingdom has outlasted others. *Its flaw:* it is not a future, only a delay — and it asks a starving, indebted, frightened kingdom to do nothing, which no kingdom can do for long.

## THE FIVE VISIONS AT A GLANCE

| VISION | CHAMPIONS | WOULD… | FATAL FLAW |
|---|---|---|---|
| **The Open Road** | Concord, Ironvow, new-forgers | Trade outward; sell aurithal; refinance debt | Spends the ward; deepens dependence on Vendholm |
| **The Closed Door** | Old Forgewrights, Khazmar | Seal the realm; hoard aurithal; default | Starvation; can't fund its own defence |
| **The Reconquest** | Korroth & his Deepward | Retake the Ninth by force | Opens the Door it means to defend |
| **The Homecoming** | The Reclaimers | Open the Ninth in devotion | Answers the Choir; serves the Throne |
| **The Silence** | The Reckoners | Change nothing; suppress; endure | A delay, not a future |

CHAPTER IV

# The Open Hand — Reform

The reform bloc is the loudest, the youngest, and the richest, and it believes — with the confidence of those who have never seen the deep up close — that Grunvyr's troubles are merely problems of trade and coin to be solved with cleverness and openness. Its strength is real: the Concord's gold, the newforgers' genius, and a candidate, in Dagra Ironvow, who could plausibly win.

## The Merchant Concord

Grunvyr's trade league, chartered in D.R. 1539, and the engine of the Open Road. The Concord wants direct dealings with Caer Ostryn, an end to Vendholm's tolls at Aldermouth, and a kingdom that faces outward. Its members are trade-thanes, caravan-masters, and the foreign-facing young who have seen the surface and want more of it.

### BRANN TRUEWEIGHT · CONCORD-SPEAKER

The Concord's head: a broad, jovial caravan-baron who built his house on the Glimmerwend gem trade and speaks of the future the way other dwarves speak of ancestors. Brann is genuinely well-meaning, genuinely brilliant at coin, and genuinely blind to the deep — he treats the Door as an old superstition and the aurithal question as mere economics. He backs Dagra with the Concord's full purse. He does not know that one of his own factors is selling the Concord's secrets to Vendholm.

## The Newforgers

The younger wing of the Forgewrights' Guild, who would experiment with aurithal rather than hoard it — new alloys, new mechanisms, new enchantments. They are Dagra's natural base within her own guild, set against the old masters (Chapter V). Brilliant, ambitious, and impatient with the Silence that forbids them to study the very metal they work.

## Clan Stonewright

The builders and engineers who keep the Delves from collapsing. Pragmatic rather than ideological, the Stonewrights lean reform because reform means building — new works, a wider Gate, fresh contracts. Their Moot-vote leans to Dagra, but it is a vote that follows the work, and could be bought back by whoever offers the grander project.

### DAGRA IRONVOW · FORGE-MASTER & CLAIMANT

Mistress of the Forgeworks, head of Clan Ironvow, and the reform candidate for the Stonecrown. Dagra is formidable: clear-eyed, disciplined, and the finest aurithal-smith of her generation. Her enemies' jibe — "the Pawnbroker's Queen" — is unfair but not baseless; she truly would sell aurithal to save the kingdom, because she does not fully believe the Reckoners' darkest warnings about what the metal is for. She is honest, which in this year makes her the easiest of the great players to predict — and to deceive. The Choir's Hand has no hook in Dagra herself. It does not need one. It need only let her win, and let her sell the ward.

CHAPTER V

# The Closed Fist — Tradition

The tradition bloc is older, grimmer, and divided against itself in a way the reformers are not. All of it agrees that the kingdom must turn inward and guard the deep; it cannot agree whether to do so by sealing the Door forever or by smashing it open and ending the threat by force. That fracture runs straight through the Deepward Order, and it is the most dangerous split in the kingdom.

## The Deepward Order

The warrior-wardens of the eighth Delve, sworn since D.R. 1206 to keep the Sealing Door shut and the Vigil unbroken. By oath and instinct they are the heart of tradition. But their own commander now preaches reconquest, and the Order is quietly tearing in two.

### KORROTH DEEPWARD · DEEP-WARDEN & CLAIMANT

Commander of the Deepward and the tradition candidate for the crown. Korroth is brave, beloved by his Wardens, and exhausted by four centuries of his Order's losing patience-game against the deep. He has talked himself into the Reconquest as the only honourable end to the dread — open the Ninth, kill what waits, and stop merely *enduring*. He believes he would be saving the kingdom. He is the Throne's most useful dwarf, for he commands the only force that could open the Door, and he wants to. He does not know the Reclaimers quietly back him, nor what that backing means.

### CAPTAIN HJALDA DOORWARD · THE OATH KEPT

A senior Door-Warden and the conscience of the Order — and Korroth's growing problem. Hjalda's oath is to the Door, not to the Deep-Warden, and she will not raise a hand to open what she has sworn to hold, crown or no crown. She has begun, carefully, to gather the Wardens who feel as she does. If the Moot turns toward Korroth and reconquest, Hjalda is the dwarf most likely to defy her own commander — making her either the kingdom's salvation or the spark of a war within the Order. The party that wins Hjalda's trust gains the deep's last honest defenders.

## The Old Forgewright Masters

The senior smiths who hold the traditions of the Guild against the newforgers, led by **Master Durgan Emberkin**. They would lock the aurithal away, study nothing, sell nothing, and keep the old secret ways. Durgan's word carries the prestige of Clan Emberkin, first finders of aurithal — and his swing of that split clan toward tradition is among the most-courted prizes in the Moot.

## Clan Khazmar

Most of the Delvers' Union leans traditionalist by temperament — the miners distrust the surface, distrust the Concord's foreign friends, and want the kingdom kept whole and close. But Khazmar's loyalty to tradition is shallower than its grievance against the great clans, and that grievance is the subject of the next chapter.

> *"Dagra would sell the mountain to feed it. Korroth would open the mountain to save it. I am old enough to remember that we were promised the deep would stay shut. I want the dwarf who will simply keep that promise. I am still waiting to meet him."*
>
> — MASTER DURGAN EMBERKIN, TO THE MOOT

CHAPTER VI

# The Balance & the Restless

Between the open hand and the closed fist stand two powers who will likely decide the whole contest: the house that holds the deciding vote, and the union that holds the picks. One is the coldest calculation in the kingdom; the other is its hottest grievance. Win either and you win Grunvyr; lose both and no crown will sit easy.

## House Goldhand

The bankers, minters, and toll-keepers of the Vaults, and holders of the seventh, undecided Moot-vote. Goldhand is officially neutral and therefore courted by all — and that neutrality is not indecision but strategy. The House follows the ledger, and the ledger says: back whoever best secures the kingdom's debts and the soundness of the coin. Goldhand will pledge late, extract everything, and land on the winning side.

### ORLA GOLDHAND · VAULT-KEEPER

Head of House Goldhand and keeper of the decisive vote. Orla is the most underestimated player in Grunvyr: patient, unsentimental, and frighteningly well-informed, for the Vaults hold the Book of Reckonings and she reads every page. She has no vision of progress at all — only of solvency. Whichever way she finally pledges will most likely crown the next monarch, and she knows it, and she is making everyone pay for the privilege of asking. What few suspect is that her neutrality is itself a covert operation; see *the Ledger*, Chapter VIII.

## The Delvers' Union

Clan Khazmar's miners — the largest body in the kingdom and the least powerful, one Moot-vote for the majority of dwarven backs. They do the deepest, deadliest work for the least say, and after centuries of it their patience has nearly run out. The talk in the lower Delves this year is of a **tool-down** — a strike — and a kingdom that cannot mine cannot pay its debts, arm its Wardens, or renew the Door's aurithal sigils. The Delvers do not know how much power they truly hold. The year they find out will reshape Grunvyr.

### STEWARD ADA PICKOATH · THE TOOL-DOWN

A blunt, beloved Delvers' steward leading the push for danger-coin, a real Moot voice, and a halt to sending miners ever deeper after the dwindling aurithal. Ada is no radical — she wants fairness, not revolution — but she is sitting on the most explosive lever in the kingdom and being courted by every faction to pull it or hold it. Korroth promises the miners glory; Dagra promises them prosperity; the Granite Oath whispers that a strike could topple a reformist crown; and something colder still has begun to whisper to the grieving among her diggers, for it is the Delvers who go deepest and come back Quieted most often.

## Clan Emberkin, Split

The first finders of aurithal, rich in prestige and poor in unity. Half of Emberkin follows Durgan into tradition; half is drawn to the newforgers' future. Their single Moot-vote is genuinely up for grabs, and both claimants spend heavily to court it. Emberkin's indecision is a fair mirror of the whole kingdom's.

CHAPTER VII

# The Reckoners & the Silence

The Reckoners' College stands apart from the spectrum, neither reform nor tradition, and that apartness is itself a position. The College keeps the law, the calendar, and the Book of Reckonings; it judges grudges and records debts; and — as Volume II set down — it keeps the Doctrine of Silence, deliberately leaving the deepest truths unwritten lest the writing of them feed the thing below. Behind its public face of dusty neutrality, the College is the most quietly powerful and the most morally compromised body in Grunvyr.

## The Public College

To most dwarves the Reckoners are clerks: they witness contracts, settle grudges, keep the years. This is true and it is a mask. Because the Book of Reckonings records who owes what to whom, the High Reckoner knows the secret finances and hidden grudges of every clan — and what the Reckoners choose to write, or not write, can make or unmake a House.

### MAEVIS STONELEDGER · HIGH RECKONER

Keeper of the Book, the calendar, and the Silence, and the only player in Grunvyr who fully understands the stakes. Maevis knows aurithal is the ward; she holds the **Sealer's Testament**; she grasps that reform spends the ward, that reconquest and homecoming open the Door, and that her own doctrine of doing-nothing is only a delay. She is not neutral — she is desperate, and her desperation makes her ruthless. To preserve the Silence she will suppress, blackmail (the Book gives her the means), and, the Unwritten whisper, worse. She is on the side of the kingdom's survival, which is not always the same as the side of any dwarf in it.

## The Unwritten

Within the College sits a secret inner order: the **Unwritten**, Reckoners sworn to carry the lore that may never be recorded — the Gloam's nature, the truth of the Ninthfall, the contents of the Sealer's Testament — mouth to ear, and to destroy any copy that escapes onto a page. They are few, old, and answerable to the High Reckoner alone. Their methods are the College's darkest secret: an Unwritten will burn a archive, ruin a scholar, or silence a witness to keep a dangerous truth from being written where the deep might read it. They are not evil. They are the immune system of a civilisation built on memory, and like any immune system they sometimes kill the body to save it.

> *"Vesska was my best pupil. She could not bear that we would not even write the names of the trapped, and she left to listen for them in the dark. Now she speaks with their voices and calls it holiness. I will stop her, and I will grieve her, and I will not write down which of those I did first."*
>
> — MAEVIS STONELEDGER

CHAPTER VIII

# Knives in the Dark

Beneath the open quarrel of the Moot run the covert ones — the powers that do not sit in any hall and are not written in any Book. Three of them are dwarven conspiracies, each the secret shadow of a public faction; the fourth, in the next chapter, is not dwarven at all. A Warden running intrigue in Grunvyr will find these the engines of every plot, for they act where the great players cannot be seen to act.

### THE LEDGER · THE BANKING CABAL

**Patron:** Vault-Keeper Orla Goldhand. **Aim:** to make House Goldhand the true power behind whichever crown wins. **Method:** the Ledger is a secret inner circle of Goldhand factors who manipulate the kingdom's debts, quietly fund both claimants, and trade the one thing more valuable than coin — the secret contents of the Book of Reckonings. Goldhand's public neutrality is the Ledger's masterwork: by pledging last and lending to all, they ensure the next monarch takes the throne already owing them. Not malicious, merely supreme — and willing to prolong the crisis itself, because a frightened, indebted kingdom is a profitable one.

### THE GRANITE OATH · THE HARDLINE CONSPIRACY

**Leader:** the warden-captain known as **Skardi Graniteoath**, a Deepward hardliner who finds even Korroth too reckless. **Aim:** to force the Closed Door by any means — seal the kingdom, default on Vendholm, and end the dangerous quarrel by ending the quarrellers. **Method:** the Oath is a cell of old-clan veterans and rigid Wardens who believe that *both* claimants are dooms — Dagra would sell the ward, Korroth would open the Door — and that the only safety is a strong hand that imposes isolation. They have begun to speak of removing a claimant rather than out-voting one. If the Moot leans the wrong way, the Granite Oath is the faction most likely to put a knife in it.

### VOSSHEIM'S PURSE · THE FOREIGN HAND

**Paymaster:** Margrave Aldric Vossheim of Vendholm, through his agent in the Hold. **Aim:** a weak, divided, debt-bound Grunvyr that Vendholm owns in all but name. **Method:** a network of bought informants and influence-peddlers, paid in foreign gold and forgiven debts. Its keystone is **Hesk Brightcoin**, a respected Merchant Concord factor who is secretly Vossheim's man — feeding the Margrave the reformers' plans while steering the Concord toward ever-deeper dependence on Vendholm coin. Exposing Hesk would gut the reform bloc's credibility; protecting the secret is worth a great deal to Vendholm, and to anyone who has taken its money.

## How the Knives Cross

These conspiracies are not allies. The Ledger profits from the very crisis the Granite Oath would end by force; Vossheim's Purse wants the dependence the Granite Oath most fears; and all three would be horrified — or claim to be — by what the next chapter describes. Yet each, in pursuing its own aim, does the deep's work for it: the Ledger prolongs the paralysis, the Oath threatens the bloodshed that would shatter the Vigil, and the Purse hollows the kingdom's will from the outside while something else hollows it from below. The knives think they fight each other. A colder hand has set them all at the same throat.

CHAPTER IX

# The Inner Enemy

Here is the secret beneath all the others, and the reason this whole volume is, in the end, a single warning. The deepest faction in Grunvyr is not a faction at all. It has no hall, no Moot-vote, and no leader who is still entirely a dwarf. It is the reach of the Pale Choir into the Hold itself — the slow infiltration of the Quieted — and the dwarves who name it at all call it the **Choir's Hand**. It does not want the crown. It wants the Door, and it has learned that the surest way to open a door is from the inside.

## What the Hand Is

As Volume II set down, the Gloamkin do not breed; they convert. The Quieting takes a dwarf by slow degrees — first calm and forgetful, then pale and hollow, then wholly turned, the body living on and wearing its old shape a while. The fully Quieted can pass among the living. The Choir's Hand is simply those Quieted who have come *up* — embedded among the delvers, the Fent-Wardens, the Reclaimers, the servants of the great Houses — patient, quiet, and bent toward one end. They are not many. They do not need to be. They are seeds, and the kingdom's own quarrels are the soil.

### THE HAND WORKS THROUGH EVERY FACTION

The Choir's Hand has no policy of its own. It has the genius of the parasite: it whispers to each faction's existing desire and bends it toward the Door.

- To the **Reclaimers**, it speaks in the voices of their lost kin — and they call it grace.
- To **Korroth**'s Deepward, it confirms that reconquest is honour — and they call it courage.
- To the **Concord**, it argues the deep is superstition and the aurithal should be sold — and they call it progress.
- To the **Granite Oath**, it feeds the fear that justifies a knife — and they call it duty.
- To the grieving **Delvers**, it offers their dead back — and they call it mercy.

Every road the factions argue over leads, by some path, to the Door. The Hand does not care which road wins. It is patient enough to wait for any of them.

## Vesska Hollowtongue, the Open Wound

The Reclaimer prophet is the Hand's masterpiece and its tragedy. Once Maevis's finest pupil, Vesska went into the Underfent to listen for the trapped and came back able to recite their very words — and her followers call it holiness. She is Quieted, or nearly, and the voice she speaks with is the Choir's, borrowing the memories of the dead it consumed. She does not know. She believes, with her whole grieving heart, that she is bringing her people home, which is exactly why she is unstoppable by argument. You cannot reason a dwarf out of a grief the enemy is feeding.

### SIGNS OF THE HAND (FOR WARDENS AND PLAYERS)

- A dwarf returned from the deep who answers to his name but never warms his hands at the hearth.
- A faction's hothead suddenly, eerily calm — and arguing, more persuasively than ever, for opening the Door.
- Fent-Wardens who volunteer for the Door-watch and grow quiet on duty.
- A servant in Karad-Vyr or the Vaults who remembers a dead dwarf's private words too exactly.
- Aurithal that goes missing in small amounts — for the Hand fears it, and would see the ward thinned.

## How Deep Does It Go?

That is the question that should keep a Warden awake. The Hand is confirmed among the Reclaimers and has certainly reached the Fent-Wardens. Whether it has touched higher — a Council servant, a faction lieutenant, a Goldhand factor, a Warden of the Door itself — is left for your table to decide, and the not-knowing is the point. In a kingdom whose entire strength is memory and trust, the deep's master-

stroke is to make every dwarf wonder whether the one beside him is still entirely himself. Maevis keeps a private list of the maybe-Quieted. She will not write it down. She is right not to.

CHAPTER X

# The Cast of the Hearth

Intrigue is people, and Grunvyr's contest comes down to a few dozen of them. This chapter gathers the volume's players into one reference for the table — who they are, where they stand in the open, and what they hide. One more belongs here who has gone unnamed until now, for he keeps the one door the whole kingdom passes through.

### GATE-WARDEN TOVAL VYR · THE DOOR ABOVE

Keeper of the Sunlit Gate, master of customs, and the most quietly important honest dwarf in the kingdom. Toval controls who enters Grunvyr from the surface — and his Gate is understaffed, his tariffs disputed, and his watch stretched thin by the very trade the reformers demand. He takes no side in the succession; he only wants the Gate kept. But an overwhelmed Gate is a porous one, and more than smugglers have slipped through it. If the Choir's Hand and Vossheim's coin reach the Hold from outside, they reach it past Toval — who would be the last to suspect it, and the first to be blamed.

### THE THREE BOARDS OF INTRIGUE

A Warden should picture Grunvyr's struggle as three boards played at once, with most pieces ignorant of the others:

- **The Moot** — the open contest for the Stonecrown's seven votes. Most dwarves think this is the whole game.
- **The Knives** — the covert war of the Ledger, the Granite Oath, and Vossheim's Purse, each manipulating the Moot from the shadows.
- **The Hand** — the deep's silent advance, which does not care who wins the first two boards so long as the Door opens.

A single act — a pledged vote, an exposed traitor, a quieted lieutenant — almost always moves all three boards at once. That is the texture of play in Grunvyr.

## THE CAST OF GRUNVYR, D.R. 1622

| NAME | ROLE | STANDS WITH (OPENLY) | WHAT THEY HIDE |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Vargin III Vyr** | Underking (failing) | — | Will name no heir; perhaps cannot |
| **Dagra Ironvow** | Forge-Master; claimant | The Open Road (reform) | Nothing — and her honesty is the danger |
| **Korroth Deepward** | Deep-Warden; claimant | The Reconquest | The Reclaimers back him; he doesn't know |
| **Orla Goldhand** | Vault-Keeper; decisive vote | Neutral | Runs the Ledger; funds both claimants |
| **Maevis Stoneledger** | High Reckoner | The Silence | Leads the Unwritten; holds the Sealer's Testament |
| **Brann Trueweight** | Concord-Speaker | Reform; backs Dagra | Harbours a traitor among his own factors |
| **Durgan Emberkin** | Old Forgewright master | The Closed Door | Holds Clan Emberkin's swing vote |
| **Ada Pickoath** | Delvers' Union steward | Khazmar; the tool-down | Her diggers are being Quieted fastest |
| **Hjalda Doorward** | Door-Warden captain | The oath; the Door | Quietly gathering Wardens to defy Korroth |
| **Toval Vyr** | Gate-Warden | Neutral | His porous Gate is the kingdom's blind spot |
| **Skardi Graniteoath** | Warden-captain | Tradition (hardline) | Leads the Granite Oath; would kill to seal |
| **Hesk Brightcoin** | Concord factor | Reform (openly) | Is Vossheim's Purse inside the Concord |
| **Vesska Hollowtongue** | Reclaimer prophet | The Homecoming | Quieted; speaks with the Choir's voice |
| **"Brother" Onkar** | Reclaimer cell-leader | The Homecoming | Fully Quieted; the Choir's Hand made flesh |
| **Aldric Vossheim** | Margrave of Vendholm | Vendholm (offstage) | Paymaster of the Purse; covets the Hold |

CHAPTER XI

# Hooks & Reckonings

Intrigue in Grunvyr is a game played on three boards at once: the open contest of the Moot, the covert war of the knives, and the silent advance of the Hand — and a move on one board is always a move on the others. Below are seeds drawn from this volume, each tied to the present year and contradicting nothing of the first two.

| INTRIGUES OF THE SUNDERED HEARTH (ROLL D10) | |
|---|---|
| 1 | Vault-Keeper Orla will pledge Goldhand's decisive vote — to whichever claimant the party can prove is the safer debtor. Both claimants would rather the party prove it about them, by any means. |
| 2 | A Concord factor, Hesk Brightcoin, is Vendholm's man. Maevis wants him exposed; the Granite Oath wants him killed; Brann Trueweight refuses to believe a word of it. |
| 3 | Steward Ada Pickoath will call the tool-down in three days. Convince her to hold — or discover who among her grieving diggers is whispering that a strike would "bring the deep up to meet them." |
| 4 | Captain Hjalda Doorward asks the party, in secret, to help her gather the Wardens who will refuse Korroth's order to open the Door — before the Moot makes that order lawful. |
| 5 | The Granite Oath means to remove a claimant. The party learns the plot — and must decide whether a kingdom is better served by a murder or by the candidate the murder would stop. |
| 6 | Maevis entrusts the party with the Sealer's Testament and a terrible choice: deliver it to the Moot to discredit the Reconquest, or burn it before the Reclaimers can read the Gloam's name from its pages. |
| 7 | Vesska Hollowtongue requests a parley. She speaks, for a moment, in the exact voice of a party member's dead kin. She is not lying. That is what makes it unbearable. |
| 8 | A beloved faction lieutenant has gone eerily calm and turned, overnight, into the most persuasive voice for opening the Ninth. Prove what he has become before the Moot listens to him. |
| 9 | Aurithal is vanishing from the Vaults in small, deniable amounts. Goldhand blames thieves; the Unwritten fear the Hand; whoever is right, the Door's sigils are dimming faster for it. |
| 10 | Underking Vargin III dies. The Moot has three days. Every faction, every knife, and the Hand itself moves at once — and the party holds one vote's worth of leverage over how Grunvyr's next age begins. |

## A Last Reckoning

The lesson of this volume is the lesson of all three: Grunvyr's troubles are not separate. The succession, the dwindling aurithal, the debt, the failing Door, the five visions, the four conspiracies — these are not a list of problems but a single wound, and the cold hand in the deep has its fingers in every part of it. The factions believe they are fighting each other for the future of the kingdom. They are. But they are doing it on a board the enemy laid out, toward an end the enemy chose, and the only move that is truly theirs is the oldest and least heroic one the Reckoners know.

> *"Keep the light. Sing. Remember. And — this is the part I add for the living, the part that is not in any Book — trust each other anyway. The deep wins the day we stop, and it wins just as surely the day we each decide the dwarf beside us is already lost. A sundered hearth is a cold one. See that ours does not go out."*
>
> — HIGH RECKONER MAEVIS STONELEDGER, CLOSING THE VOLUME

HERE ENDS VOLUME III OF THE GAZETTEER OF GRUNVYR
❖ A RECKONING OF LOYALTIES · D.R. 1622 ❖